



Turkey and the Caucasus

TURKEY LIES IN BOTH ASIA and Europe—separated by the Bosphorus—and was once part of the powerful Ottoman Empire. Although the population is 99 percent Muslim, modern Turkey is a country with no official religion. Western Turkey is relatively industrialized, with a tourist industry along the Mediterranean coast that brings in considerable income. Many farmers and herders in the center and east, however, struggle to make a living in the arid environment. To the northeast lie the Caucasus countries of Georgia, Azerbaijan, and Armenia. Once part of the USSR, they are now independent.



ISTANBUL
The different faces of Turkey can be seen in its former capital, Istanbul, which lies on both sides of the Bosphorus waterway. Churches, mosques, and ancient buildings in both European and Islamic styles sit side by side with modern shops and offices. Bridges link the two parts of the city. In 1923, Ankara became the new capital.



TURKISH FOOD
Turkey is self-sufficient in food and grows specialized crops such as eggplants, peppers, figs, and dates. A typical Turkish meal might consist of spiced lamb, often grilled on a skewer with onion and tomato to make a *shish kebab*. This would be served with rice or cracked wheat.



EPHESUS
Tourism is one of Turkey's major industries. As well as beach resorts, the country has many ancient sites. One of these is the old Greek city of Ephesus, which lies 35 miles (56 km) south of modern-day Izmir on the Aegean coast. The city was famous for its Temple of Artemis, which was considered one of the seven wonders of the world.

Visitors to Ephesus admiring the remains of the Library of Celsus

FATHER OF THE TURKS
Mustafa Kemal Atatürk (1881–1938), founder of the modern Turkish state, became its first president in 1923. He introduced many reforms, including more equality for women and better education for all. He also declared that Islam was no longer to be the official religion.

